

A Forgotten Forest Experiment Grew Giant Trees

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In Australia, people have argued for years about forests. Some want them fully protected. Others want to cut trees for wood and jobs.

In the late 1980s, the state of Victoria started a big **experiment** in its mountain ash forests. Mountain ash trees are some of the tallest trees in the world. In some areas, every tree was cut. In "heavily **thinned**" areas, 50 to 70 percent of the trees were cut. Other areas were left alone.

Later, the **experiment** was forgotten. Then in 2014, researchers from the University of Melbourne visited and were amazed.

In the **thinned** areas, the trees left behind had grown huge. The biggest were 20 percent wider than the biggest trees in untouched forest. The **thinned** forest also stored as much **carbon** as untouched forest, or more.

Cameras found rare Leadbeater's **possums** in every cut area the team checked, but none in untouched areas.

Word Treasure

experiment -- A test scientists do to find something out.

thinned -- When some trees are cut so the others have more space.

carbon -- A substance trees store in their wood as they grow.

possum -- A small furry animal that lives in trees.

Break it down

A long argument about forests

The experiment begins

The experiment is forgotten and found again

Big trees and stored carbon

Rare possums in the cut areas

Why it matters

It shows that careful forest care might help people get wood while still helping trees and animals.

Test what you remember

1. What have people in Australia argued about for years?

- ☐ (A) How to take care of forests
- ☐ (B) How to build cars
- ☐ (C) Which sport is best
- ☐ (D) What to name a river

2. What kind of trees were in the experiment?

- ☐ (A) Mountain ash trees
- ☐ (B) Pine trees from Canada
- ☐ (C) Palm trees
- ☐ (D) Apple trees

3. In "heavily thinned" areas, how many trees were cut?

- ☐ (A) 50 to 70 percent
- ☐ (B) Just one tree
- ☐ (C) None
- ☐ (D) Every single tree

4. When did researchers visit the forgotten experiment?

- ☐ (A) In 1880
- ☐ (B) In 2050
- ☐ (C) In 2014
- ☐ (D) Last week

5. What happened to the trees left in thinned areas?

- ☐ (A) They all fell down
- ☐ (B) They stopped growing
- ☐ (C) They grew huge
- ☐ (D) They turned purple

6. Where did cameras find Leadbeater's possums?

- ☐ (A) Only in untouched forest
- ☐ (B) In every cut area the team checked
- ☐ (C) Nowhere at all
- ☐ (D) In a city park

Answer key (try the quiz first!): 1: A 2: A 3: A 4: C 5: C 6: B

Questions to think about

1. People who want forests protected: Want forests left fully untouched.
2. People who support harvesting: Want trees cut for wood to support local jobs.

MY THOUGHTS (at least 20 words):